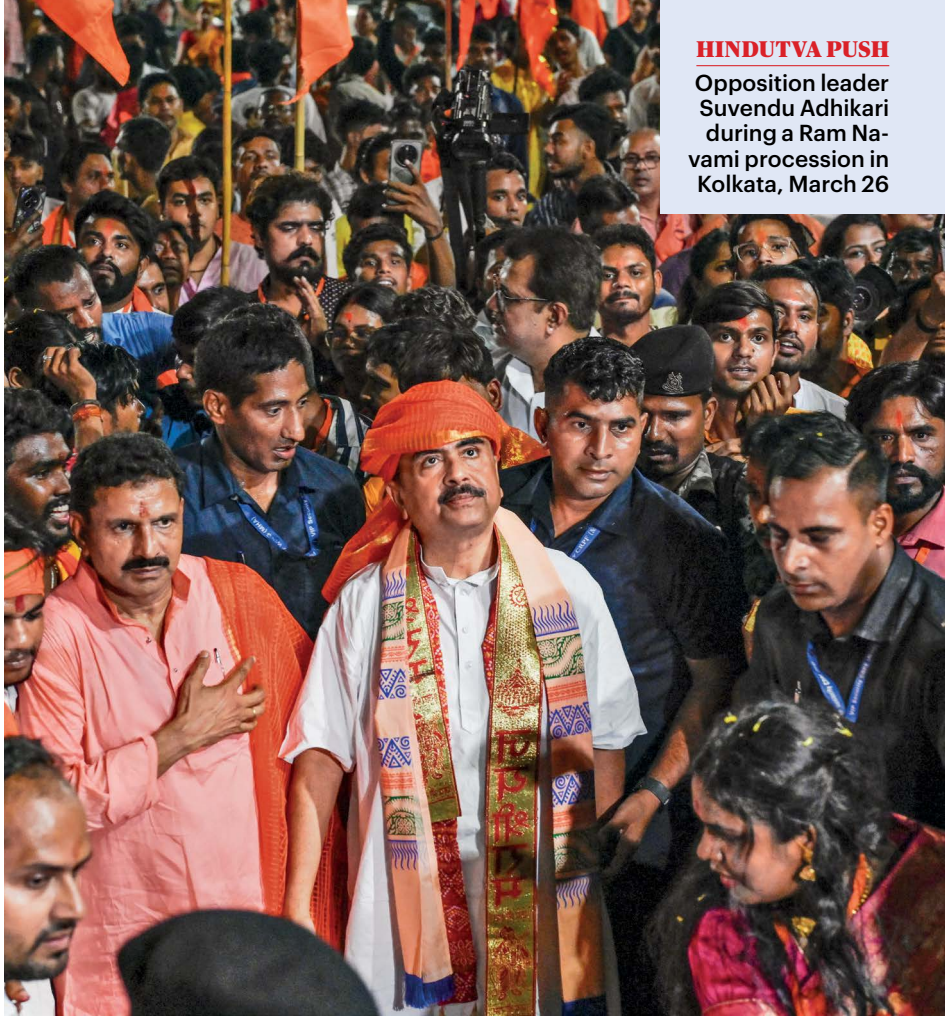


HINDUTVA PUSH
Opposition leader Suvendu Adhikari during a Ram Navami procession in Kolkata, March 26

suggest around 45 per cent deletions. Hence Mamata's rechristening of chief election commissioner Gyanesh Kumar as 'Vanish Kumar'.

Despite the SIR setbacks, Abhishek Banerjee, Mamata's nephew and TMC national general secretary, claims the party will surpass its 2021 tally of 215. However, inside the TMC, there is quiet unease. Party estimates suggest that if this deletion pattern continues, outcomes in 20 seats could be affected, bringing their tally down to roughly 195. Of the 6.06 million names that went into adjudication, nearly 2.8 million are women, Mamata's core voters. Even before adjudication began, more than 3.1 million women had been deleted under various categories, compared with about 2.7 million men.

Despite SIR setbacks, TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee claims the party will surpass its 2021 tally of 215. But within the party, there is quiet unease

Welfare Dividend

That sense of a core constituency relates directly to how she has crafted her long-running welfare apparatus. Under Lakshmir Bhandar, launched in February 2021, 22.1 million women receive financial support. The monthly allowance now stands at Rs 1,500 for the general category and Rs 1,700 for Scheduled Castes (SC) and Scheduled Tribes (ST) households. Similarly, under Rupashree, over 2.20 million women have received Rs 25,000 each for marriage assistance. No wonder, at the Laudoha rally, Mamata did not have to prompt the women in the crowd to perform *ululu*, the ritualistic sound that has become a signature of her meetings. It erupted spontaneously, punctuating her speech.

The welfare ecosystem extends to a broad spectrum of vulnerable groups and occupational categories. The Karmasathi (Parijayee Shramik) scheme safeguards migrant workers, while Shramashree promises Rs 5,000 monthly support to 3.18 million returning workers until they find employment—both touted as achievements in addressing labour vulnerability. Pension schemes like Jai Johar and Taposili Bandhu have disbursed Rs 9,108.45 crore to 1.46 million SC and ST senior citizens. Farmers have received Rs 27,016 crore under Krishak Bandhu, and crop insurance under Bangla Shasya Bima has protected 11.3 million farmers, with claims worth Rs 3,938 crore settled. The outreach also targets younger voters. Under the Banglar Yuba Sathi scheme, unemployed youth are pro-

THE CHALLENGER

Suvendu Adhikari, 55, BJP
Opposition leader, West Bengal

KEY STRATEGIES

- **Running a campaign centred on Hindu consolidation, seeking to polarise the electorate**
- **Amplifying corruption allegations against the TMC, focusing on alleged job scams, coal and cattle smuggling cases**
- **Suvendu positions himself as Mamata's principal challenger, taking her on in Bhabanipur while defending Nandigram. The move turns the contest into a direct leadership battle**
- **With direct attacks on Mamata, he energises the BJP's core base, attempting to create a perception of an inevitable political shift**
- **Supports SIR as a corrective measure against 'illegal voters'—the alleged 'Bangladeshi Muslim immigrants' and 'Rohingyas'**